

1 AN ACT relating to state symbols.

2 WHEREAS, the Treeing Walker Coonhound is a native Kentucky dog breed,
3 developed in the 19th century by two Kentucky breeders, John W. Walker and George
4 Washington Maupin, in Madison County; and

5 WHEREAS, the Treeing Walker Coonhound is a hunting breed known to chase
6 quarry into trees, thus giving hunters a clear shot at game; and

7 WHEREAS, the Treeing Walker Coonhound is known for hunting raccoons, but is
8 also used for hunting other game, including animals ranging in size from rodents to bears;
9 and

10 WHEREAS, Treeing Walker Coonhounds are fast, sensible hunters with clear,
11 ringing bugle voices; and

12 WHEREAS, Treeing Walker Coonhounds locate their quarry quickly by following
13 the freshest scent available, and they exhibit superb endurance; and

14 WHEREAS, Treeing Walker Coonhounds are also great companion dogs, known
15 for their loyalty and intelligence, kindness to children, and the ability to get along with
16 other dogs; and

17 WHEREAS, the breed was originally known as the Walker Coonhound Treeing and
18 was recognized by the United Kennel Club in 1905 as a part of the English Coonhound
19 breed. The name was changed to Treeing Walker Coonhound as a separate breed in 1945;
20 and

21 WHEREAS, the Treeing Walker Coonhound became a recognized breed of the
22 American Kennel Club in January 2012, and referenced by the AKC as "the people's
23 choice" among coonhounds; and

24 WHEREAS, animal shelters across the Commonwealth of Kentucky serve all 120
25 counties and care for tens of thousands of animals each year, most of which are dogs and
26 cats being both purebred and mixed breeds; and

27 WHEREAS, more than 60,000 animals enter Kentucky shelters each year, placing

1 substantial demands on local communities and their fiscal resources; and

2 WHEREAS, increasing public awareness of animals in shelters or in the care of
3 rescue organizations can lead to higher adoption rates for those purebred and mixed-
4 breed animals; and

5 WHEREAS, many dogs, including breeds with deep Kentucky roots, purebreds,
6 and mixed breeds alike, become loyal companions in homes across the Commonwealth
7 of Kentucky; and

8 WHEREAS, it is fitting that as Kentucky designates an official state dog, that the
9 General Assembly also recognizes the importance of promoting the adoption and
10 responsible care of purebred and mixed-breed animals in shelters and in rescue
11 organizations; and

12 WHEREAS, the eastern spotted skunk and eastern hellbender are native, nongame
13 species historically present within Kentucky; and

14 WHEREAS, the eastern hellbender is classified as a species of greatest
15 conservation concern, and the eastern spotted skunk is classified as a species of high
16 conservation concern; and

17 WHEREAS, official recognition of these species promotes environmental
18 education, conservation awareness, and appreciation of Kentucky's natural heritage
19 without fiscal or regulatory impact;

20 NOW, THEREFORE,

21 ***Be it enacted by the General Assembly of the Commonwealth of Kentucky:***

22 ➔SECTION 1. A NEW SECTION OF KRS CHAPTER 2 IS CREATED TO
23 READ AS FOLLOWS:

24 ***The Treeing Walker Coonhound is named and designated as the official state dog of***
25 ***Kentucky.***

26 ➔SECTION 2. A NEW SECTION OF KRS CHAPTER 2 IS CREATED TO
27 READ AS FOLLOWS:

1 Domestic cats (*Felis catus*) and dogs (*Canis familiaris*), both purebred and mixed
2 breeds alike, that reside in or have been adopted from Kentucky animal shelters or
3 rescue organizations are named and designated as the official pets of the
4 Commonwealth of Kentucky.

5 ➔SECTION 3. A NEW SECTION OF KRS CHAPTER 2 IS CREATED TO
6 READ AS FOLLOWS:

7 The eastern spotted skunk (*Spilogale putorius*) is named and designated as the official
8 state nongame mammal of Kentucky.

9 ➔SECTION 4. A NEW SECTION OF KRS CHAPTER 2 IS CREATED TO
10 READ AS FOLLOWS:

11 The eastern hellbender (*Cryptobranchus alleganiensis*) is named and designated as the
12 official state amphibian of Kentucky.